

programmers as well as software product development teams or organisations.

Software developers are problem solvers by nature. They enjoy the art of seeing a problem, planning a solution, and writing code that solves the problem. At the same time, they get annoyed at anything that gets in the way of trying to solve the problem. Free and open source tools give developers the transparency to dive into problems that they wouldn't be able to tackle in a proprietary 'black-box' solution. I can't tell you how many times I've seen developers wish they could somehow fix a problem in a proprietary compiler or library.

For organisations and teams, it's even more vital, because as the size of the teams grows, so does the level of communication required to keep people up to date with the latest information. My own experience has been that in proprietary software teams, any given piece of code might get reviewed by two or three people, if you're lucky. In open source projects, that number tends to be much higher. And, even if you're using open source tools to build proprietary software, the ability to get lower-level insight into how the tools are working—and the flexibility to change them—keeps programmers productive.

Q Are there any pitfalls when working on open source platforms? If so, how can these be dealt with?

Sure. Open source isn't always the most efficient software development model. It just happens to be the only one I've found that is sustainable over the long run.

Obviously, the other potential issue with open source platforms is that because people have a voice in how the software is developed, you tend to see a lot of heated discussions between people who are very passionate about the software they are working on but have differing opinions. Unfortunately, the tone of these discussions often scares off the very people who are willing to help make the software better.

Q You have been an avid speaker at many FOSS events. Which are the subjects that particularly interest you—the ones that you would like to advocate to the audiences you address?

Yes, I very much enjoy speaking at FOSS events and getting the opportunity to meet people who put tremendous effort and time into free and open source software. What I most often try to instil in those who listen to my talks is to be bold in your efforts to change the world, but be humble enough to realise that others have the knowledge that might help you in your quest.

Another point I've been talking about lately is the fact that FOSS isn't getting as much buzz as it did a decade ago. I explain that this is a very healthy sign because it means FOSS is now so commonplace that

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people don't need to highlight it as something odd or as the 'shiny new object'. The task before us is to continue on with the same level of enthusiasm, even though we might not be getting as much attention around our efforts.

Q Are there many challenges that open source developers may have shared with you at such events?

There are always going to be challenges and problems. Smart people will be passionate about their software, sometimes even to a fault. Companies will try to use short-cuts to gain money at the expense of FOSS users and developers. In the end, however, I'm very optimistic about the future. We've already begun to see the fruits of our labour, and things are only going to get better in the years to come.

Summing up...

Q We are celebrating the 20th anniversary of Linux this year. You also have been an early adopter of Linux and FOSS. How would you recapitulate this journey, and how do you see Linux and open source evolving?

I see the evolution of Linux and FOSS as a journey of hope and opportunity. Linux started out small and inconspicuous and look how far it has come now. I remember in the early days of FOSS, a lot of effort was put into duplicating the functionality of existing proprietary systems. Today, FOSS is pioneering work in a vast array of different areas and we are the ones pioneering the trail to the future.

Q What is your message to *LINUX For You* readers (primarily Linux and open source enthusiasts comprising newbies, developers, systems administrators and geeks)?

My message to your readers would be to be bold and make the decision to take a more active role in at least one FOSS project over the next month. It doesn't have to be writing code—it could be writing documentation, doing testing, submitting a bug report, helping with translation or internationalisation. It could even be doing artwork, design, marketing or any number of other things. All you need to do is be bold. Stop being passive about FOSS.

Don't be afraid to take that first small step. Then put your other foot in front of the first and you will find joy in the journey. There is a world of opportunity awaiting you. **END** 